Standard Loneliness Package

By Charles Yu

NARRATOR: **(Pg 3-34)** Don't feel like having a bad day? Let someone else have it for you. That's a line from one of our commercials. It shows a rich executive sitting and rubbing his temples, making the TV face to communicate the stress of his situation. There are wavy lines on either side of his temples to indicate that the Executive is! really! stressed! Then he places a call to his broker, and in the next scene, the Executive is lying on a beach looking at the bluest ocean I have ever seen.

Root canal is one fifty, give or take, depending on who's doing it to you. A migraine is two hundred. Death of a cousin is five hundred. Death of a sibling is twelve-fifty. Parents are two thousand a piece, but depending on the situation people will pay all kinds of money, for all kinds of reasons, for bad reasons, or for no reason at all.

Don't feel like having a bad day? Let ***me*** have it for you—me and the other six hundred operators in building D, cubicle block 4. Not that ***I*** get the money. The company

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gets it. What ***I*** get is twelve dollars an hour, plus reimbursement for painkillers. Not that they work.

I feel pain for money. Other people's pain. Physical, emotional, you name it. Pain is an illusion, I know, I know, I know. The shift manager never stops reminding us. Doesn't help, actually. Doesn't help when you are on your third broken leg of the day.

INTRODUCTION

Society hasn't achieved this level of technological innovation. ***Not yet.*** *But as musical artist Steven Wilson once said: We* ***are*** *living in dystopia, in a world that is dominated by technology and disconnect, alienation, loneliness and dysfunction. How much longer will it be before our AI assistant notices we are feeling a bit blue and suggests:*

(chipper media commercial voice) Don't feel like having a bad day? Let someone else have it for you!

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NARRATOR: I get to work late and already there are nine tickets in my inbox. I close my eyes, take a deep breath, open the first ticket of the day: I am at a funeral. I am feeling a mixture of things. Grief, mostly, but I also detect some guilt in there. There usually is. I hear crying. I am

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seeing crying, pretty, white faces. Nice clothes.

Our services aren't cheap. So the faces are usually pretty, the clothes are usually nice. The people are usually nice, too. Although, I imagine it's easy to be nice when you are rich and pretty. Even when you're at a funeral.

There's a place in Hyderabad that is doing what we're doing, a little more towards the budget end of things. Precision Living Solutions, it's called. And of course there are hundreds of emotional engineering firms in Bangalore. Springing up everywhere you look. I read in the paper that a new call center opens every three days.

Okay. Body is going into the ground now. The crying is getting more serious. Here it comes. The one that these people get a lot, near the end of a funeral service. These sad and pretty people. It's a big feeling. It feels like a huge boot is stepping on my chest. It is hard to breathe. It doesn't hurt, exactly. It's not comfortable, but it's not pain. More like pressure. Deepak, who used to be in the next cubicle, once told me that this feeling is actually the American experience of the Christian God.

I endure a few more minutes and then when the grief and

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guilt are almost too much and I wonder if I am going to have to hit the safety button, there it is. It's usually there at the end of a funeral, no matter how awful, no matter how hard I am crying, no matter how much guilt my client has saved up for me to feel . . . You wouldn't expect it -- I didn't -- It seems unbelievable, but it's almost always there, even if it's just a glimmer. Relief.

Deep always tried to explain to me how it works: The clients, they call their account reps and book the time. And then at the appointed hour, a switch in their implant chip kicks on and starts transferring their consciousness over. Perceptions, sensory data, all of it. It gets downloaded onto our servers and then dumped into our queue, which parcels out the individual jobs to all of us in the cubicle farm.

It's based on some kind of efficiency algorithm -- our historical performance, our current emotional load. Sensors in our head measure our stress levels to see what we can handle. They seem to have gotten it down to a science --How much a human being can take in a given twelve-hour shift. Grief, embarrassment, humiliation, all

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different, of course, so they calibrate our schedules, mix it up, the timing and the order, and the end result is you leave work every day at your exact breaking point. Sometimes when I get home, I'm still shaking. I sit on my couch and let it subside.

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NARRATOR: Death of an aunt is seven hundred. Death of an uncle is six. Kid's recital is one twenty-five an hour. Church is one-fifty. The only category that we will not quote a price on is death of a child. Death of a child is separately negotiated. Hardly anyone can afford it. And not all operators can handle it. We have to be specially trained to be eligible for those tickets. People go on sick leave, disability. Most people just physically cannot do it. There hasn't been one booked the whole time I've been here. The rumor is that if you do one, you are allowed to take the rest of the month off.

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NARRATOR: When I get to work the next morning, my first ticket of the day is a death bed. But this isn't regular death bed. They are pulling the plug on grandpa this morning. I open the ticket. I am holding grandpa's hand.

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He squeezes my hand, one last burst of strength. It hurts. Then his hand goes limp and his arm falls away. I cry, and also, I ***really*** cry. Meaning, not just as my client, but ***I*** start crying, too. Sometimes it happens. I don't know why, exactly. Maybe because he was somebody's grandpa. And he looked like a nice one, a nice man. Maybe something about the way his arm fell against the guard rail on the hospital bed. Maybe because I could sort of tell, when grandpa was looking at his grandson for the last time, looking into his eyes, looking around in there trying to find him, he didn't find him, he found me instead, and he knew what had happened, and he didn't even look mad. Just hurt.

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- I am in a dentist's chair.
- I am quitting my job. This is a popular one. Clients like to avoid the awkwardness of quitting, so they set an appointment, walk into their bosses' offices and tell them where they can stick this effing job, and right before their boss starts to reply, the switch kicks in and I get yelled at.
- I am losing someone to cancer.

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NARRATOR: Eleven tickets, including a two-hour adultery confession. To my husband of twenty-six years.

I'm flipped to green. You can be flipped to green, or flipped to red. You can be there or can just feel the feeling.

This is the one improvement they have made that actually benefits us workers. There's a toggle switch on the headset. Flip it to green and you get a rendering of the client's visual field. You see what he sees. Flip it to red and you still feel all of the feelings, but you see what you see.

You can do whatever you want, so long as you don't leave your cubicle. You can just stare at the cube-divider wall, or play computer solitaire, or even chat with neighbors, although that is strongly discouraged. I was hesitant at first, but more and more these days I am usually flipped to red. Except for funerals. Funerals, I like to be there, out of some kind of respect.

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NARRATOR: I am in a hospice. I have been here before. A

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regular client. My husband is gone. He died years ago. Today is the tenth anniversary of his death. I have Alzheimer's, I think. I am holding a pen. I have just written something on a notepad in front of me. I tear off the sheet -- read it to myself. It is a suicide note. A memory of my husband surfaces, like a white-hot August afternoon, resurfacing in the cool water of November. I raise a glass to my mouth, swallow a pill. Catch a glance of my note to the world. The failsafe kicks on, just in time. The system overrides. I close the ticket.

- I am at a funeral.
- I am in drug rehabilitation.
- I am in surgery.
- I am bleeding to death.

It doesn't hurt at all. I go home. I rest. I come back and do it again.

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NARRATOR: When Deep was happy, before it got bad and then worse and then even worse, he loved telling stories. About a week before he cracked up, he told me a story about a guy at Managed Life Solutions, a physical suffering shop across town, who somehow made

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arrangements with a prominent banker who wanted to kill his wife. The banker was going to do it, but he didn't want the guilt. Plus, he thought it might help with his alibi if he didn't have any memory.

Could never happen, I say. There are twenty reasons why that wouldn't work. It's just too much.

Too much what? There is no upper bound on cruelty, he said.

The next Monday, I came to work, and they were pulling Deep out the door -- two paramedics, each one with an arm under Deep's arms, and two security guards trailing behind. I wanted to say something, anything, to make them stop. I knew I would never see him again. But I froze. As they dragged him past me, I tried to make eye contact, but I looked in there, and no one was left.

And then the next day, there it was, in the newspaper. The whole story about the banker. Exactly how Deepak told it to me. There were rumors that he was the one the banker hired; he was living with murderous guilt. Other people gossiped that he had done the death of a child.

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I don't think it was either. I don't think it was any ***one*** thing that did it. There is no upper bound on sadness. There is no lower bound on decency. Deep saw it, he understood it, what was out there, and he let it seep in, and once it was in, it got all the way in, and it will never come out.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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